

Flamenco and el cante jondo

Flamenco is a range of flamboyant singing styles and dances associated primarily with the gitanos, the wanderers of southern Spain. It exists both as folk music and as professional entertainment. Falla was especially attracted to el cante jondo (“the deep song”), which was often sung without guitar accompaniment, expressing dark themes of anguish and death. Falla mounted a festival in Granada in 1922, in association with the poet Federico García Lorca, to encourage amateur singers of el cante jondo and stimulate public interest in authentic flamenco, which was increasingly threatened by the rise of the modern urbanized world.



PORTRAIT OF PASTORA IMPERIO, JULIO
ROMERO DE TORRES, 1922

Manuel María de los Dolores Falla y Matheu was born in Cádiz, Andalusia, in 1876, and studied at the Royal Conservatory of Music in Madrid. Under the influence of composer and musicologist Felipe Pedrell (1841–1922), he began exploring the diversity of Spain’s musical traditions, and in particular the folk songs and dances of Andalusia, which formed the basis for his